

health HEART

HEART ATTACK?

SORRY, TOO LATE

Minutes matter when you are having a heart attack. A new study shows how Indians mess up their chances of recovery by reaching hospitals late.

■ By Damayanti Datta

In the silence of the night, he listens to his beating heart. It has been a long day. When someone asks, he says he is fine. But alone now, tossing and turning in bed, he is gripped with loneliness, fear and exhaustion. Rajan Tewari, a 57-year-old Delhiite, has always enjoyed good health. He is energetic, a fanatic follower of TV-yoga and is always advocating the benefits of an active life. But early this morning as Tewari was out walking through his neighbourhood, the chest pain returned—the same pain that had been nagging him for the past four weeks. It wasn't even a pain, just a little discomfort that went away after a few minutes. But today it was different. No matter what he did, it just wouldn't go. He cut his walk short, went home, popped in some antacids and waited. He fretted, he lay down, he prayed, he sat up and finally called up his doctor. That was this morning—the time that he can't stop thinking about now.

Doctors have become proficient at combating heart attacks, but they are running into an unexpected obstacle:

the patient. Every second counts in a heart attack. But all too often people delay going to the hospital, sometimes waiting for hours before seeking help. "The longer the delay, the greater the chance of damage to the heart and the lower the chance of survival," says Dr D. Prabhakaran, former professor of cardiology at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) and one of the authors of a new study on why Indians report heart attacks late. Published last month in the prestigious medical journal, *The Lancet*, the study has created excitement the world over. With coronary heart diseases rising threefold in three decades in India, it provides a new angle to the country's sliding heart-health.

A heart attack means the death of heart muscle (myocardium) from the sudden blockage of a coronary artery—feeding blood and oxygen to the heart—by a blood clot. "Each minute that the heart is deprived of oxygen increases the chances of damaging or destroying part of the muscle," points out Dr Prem Pais of the St John's National Academy

6 hours: The average time taken by an Indian heart attack victim